



Access to WIC Services During Natural Disasters/Emergencies

Policy: This Colorado WIC disaster plan is intended to minimize the negative impact of program disruptions to WIC operations and services and ensure the availability of authorized supplemental foods to the extent feasible during an emergency/disaster. WIC clinics must make options available for clients who cannot come to regularly scheduled appointments.

Regulation: CFR 246.4(a)(23), USDA Guide to Coordinating WIC Services During Disaster

Procedure/Additional Guidance:

Emergencies, natural disasters and, extreme weather, can prevent either clients or local staff from traveling to the clinic. As clinics consider WIC accessibility, it is important to ensure WIC services are accessible by offering the following:

- Reschedule client's appointment to the next available time slot within the same month if they miss their scheduled appointment. If rescheduling, due to clinic appointment availability, would result in delayed or missed food benefits, agencies should issue enough monthly food benefits to ensure there are no gaps in the client's benefits until their next scheduled appointment whenever possible.
- Certify as soon as possible or within 10 days of their request for WIC benefits.
- Offer remote appointments to provide flexibility and convenience.
 - In times of disaster, clients may not be able or interested in completing nutrition education via phone or wichealth.org. In such cases, provide the nutrition education at the next visit. If contacting currently scheduled clients to issue benefits, document in the Care Plan that the reason nutrition education was not provided is due to a disaster.
- Set aside weekly or monthly time slots for clients to make up missed appointments.
- Offer same day or extended hours including lunchtime, weekends, and evenings, if possible.
- Extend an infant's or child's certification period when possible.
- If a client is coming from out-of-state, ask for a Verification of Certification (VOC). For those without a VOC, staff should attempt to obtain one to use as proof of both income and nutritional risk eligibility. For a list of state VOC contacts click this link: <https://www.fns.usda.gov/wic/wic-contacts>.
- Upon certification, provide Colorado WIC VOC information to help with the continuation of benefits when the client returns to their home State.
- Families affected by disaster may temporarily move in with another household. The displaced individuals may be considered homeless and treated as a separate household or economic unit. If families are unable to provide the required proof of identity, income and/or address, they may use the affidavit option.

Formula Issuance and Replacement

During an emergency/disaster, obtaining medical documentation may be challenging. In such cases, medical authorization for formulas can be accepted over the phone for up to 1 month, instead of the standard 2 weeks. Written documentation is required for the issuance of medical formulas and nutritionals beyond 1 month. For clients who were previously on WIC in another state, staff should make an effort to obtain the VOC. However, clinics may issue one month of benefits of any special formula or medical food that the client states they were previously receiving before evacuating.

- **Formula Replacement:** During a disaster, Colorado WIC may replace infant formula and nutritionals that were destroyed. Only formula/nutritionals purchased in the current benefit month can be replaced. State agency staff will provide specific guidance on formula replacement specific to the situation through normal Colorado WIC communication channels, including email, staff newsletters, and director meetings.
 - For individual emergencies including but not limited to house fires, floods, and theft, please review the Exchange and Replacement of Benefits policy for guidance.



- Formula Delivery: Local agency staff should use all available options to ensure clients can obtain the necessary formula during a disaster. If formulas are not available at grocery stores or if clients are unable to travel to stores due to a disaster, staff should place orders using the [Ordering Instructions for Products Not on Retail Shelves](#) procedure.
 - During a presidentially declared disaster, formula may be delivered to homes by Colorado WIC specialty pharmacies without obtaining State Office permission. Local agency staff should continue to follow standard procedures for placing formula orders.

For any formula-related issues or concerns during a disaster, local agency staff should email cdphe.wicformula@state.co.us. Please note this email address is for WIC staff use only, and should not be provided to WIC clients. WIC clients and external partners should use askwic@state.co.us for [inquiries](#).